

DREAMING AGES HISTORY · BEDTIME COMPANION

The Ottoman Sultan's Palace

One night in Topkapı, around 1720

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A BEDTIME COMPANION

A map of the palace on Sarayburnu, the four courts of a spring night under Ahmed III, the real places and people behind the story, and a short list of places to visit, for the evenings when you would like to walk a little further.

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THE HEADLAND

Topkapı on Sarayburnu

Let's begin on the headland where the palace meets the water.



Sarayburnu and the palace plotted at their real locations on a modern map (Natural Earth). The headland looks toward the Marmara, Üsküdar and the Golden Horn. Before the palace, the headland was known as Zeytinlik, the olive grove.

AT A GLANCE

- Late spring around 1720, while Ahmed III rules
- Four courts between the Golden Horn, the Bosphorus and the Marmara
- Entered from the city through the Imperial Gate
- The closer you came to the ruler, the quieter the world became

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Places you'll visit in the episode

A short, slow tour of the real places behind the story.

The Imperial Gate (Bab-ı Hümayun) · The largest outer gate, a two-storey cut-stone gatehouse where the Divanyolu met the palace, directly behind Hagia Sophia; Ali b. Yahya es-Sufi signed its inscription in 1478.

The first court · The open square between the Imperial Gate and the Gate of Salutation; soldiers and the public could enter here. Hagia Irene stands in this court and was used as an armoury.

The Gate of Salutation (Babüsselam) · Also called the Middle Gate, with two towers; the real start of the imperial palace. One iron leaf is signed by Isa b. Mehmed and dated 931 (1524–1525).

The second court · Divan Square, the administrative centre between the Middle Gate and the Gate of Felicity, with the imperial kitchens on the right.

The Tower of Justice · Rises behind a grilled window of the council hall so the sultan could watch the divan without being seen.

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Places you'll visit in the episode

The imperial kitchens · Fill the right side of the second court; Mimar Sinan rebuilt them after the fire of June 1574. The helvahane made sherbets, jams, helvas and pastes.

The Gate of Felicity (Babüssaade) · The threshold of the Enderun, remodelled in 1774–1775; beyond it lie the page wards, the treasury and the Privy Chamber.

Ahmed III's library · Opened in November 1719 in the third court behind the Audience Chamber, on the site of Selim II's pool kiosk. Books were not to be taken out.

The fourth-court terraces · The garden of kiosks northeast of the third court, overlooking the water, including the Revan Kiosk (after 1635) and the Baghdad Kiosk (about 1639).

The Ahmed III Fountain · Stands in the square between the Imperial Gate and Hagia Sophia, outside the palace wall (1728–1729).

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Through the courts, around 1720

Here is the evening walk, court by court.

THE NIGHT AT A GLANCE

Dusk	Kitchens	Library	Dawn
The outer gate	Warmth and work	Books that stay	Water and light

The walk follows the changing sounds of one palace evening under Ahmed III (1703–1730). The palace, buildings and customs are historical; the ordinary people of this particular evening are imagined.

Dusk on the headland — The route begins at the Imperial Gate and the road outside the wall.

The first court — Bread, horses and the open square; Hagia Irene as the armoury.

The Middle Gate — Two towers mark the start of the imperial house.

The council hall — The Tower of Justice looks down through its grilled window.

The kitchens — Warmth from the Matbah-ı Amire and the helvahane.

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ONE SPRING NIGHT

From the inner gate to dawn

Beyond the Gate of Felicity the house grows quieter still.



The Gate of Felicity	A young page keeps his place at the inner threshold.
The inner wards	Beds, pantry stores and the ordered life of the Enderun.
The new library	Shutters closed over books that must stay in the room.
The garden terraces	Revan and Baghdad kiosks above the dark water.
Water before dawn	The fountain by the library stair, and the first pale light.

Late spring around 1720. Ahmed III's library had opened in November 1719. The Tulip Era name for 1718–1730 was not used in eighteenth-century chronicles; it was first applied later by Yahya Kemal Beyatlı.

A WIDER MAP

The palace and its shores

Now let's step back and see the shores and cities that touch this house.



Topkapı on the Bosphorus, with Revan and Baghdad named for the campaigns that gave two kiosks their titles.

FROM FAR AND NEAR

- The Revan Kiosk remembers the 1635 campaign
- The Baghdad Kiosk remembers the 1638 reconquest
- Ahmed III's library opened in November 1719

A WIDER MAP

People you'll meet

The real names, and a few imagined ones, that you'll hear along the way.

Ahmed III · Sultan from 1703 to 1730; in 1720 the reigning owner of the palace, and builder of the library (1719) and the fountain outside the Imperial Gate (1728–1729).

Mehmed II · Ordered the New Palace after the conquest of Constantinople and took up residence there in 1478.

Ali b. Yahya es-Sufi · Calligrapher who signed the inscription on the Imperial Gate (1478).

Mimar Sinan · Rebuilt the palace kitchens after the fire of June 1574.

Murad IV · Had the Revan Kiosk built after 1635 and the Baghdad Kiosk after the 1638 reconquest of Baghdad.

Selim I · Brought the holy relics to Istanbul; the Privy Chamber came to be known as the Apartment of the Holy Mantle.

A WIDER MAP

People you'll meet

Nevşehirli Damad İbrahim Pasha · Grand vizier from 9 May 1718 until 1 October 1730; urged the building of the Ahmed III Fountain.

Hafız Osman · Taught calligraphy to Ahmed III while Ahmed was still a prince; died 3 December 1698.

İbrahim Müteferrika · Received permission in early July 1727 to open the first Turkish press.

Yirmisekiz Çelebi Mehmed Efendi · Left for France on 7 October 1720 and returned on 8 October 1721; his observations shaped later garden building.

The bostancıbaşı · Steered the sultan's boat and kept the registers of the yalıs; the only man in the palace besides the sultan allowed to wear a beard.

Ordinary people of this evening · Imagined: a page at the Gate of Felicity and others along the route. People very like them lived in these courts.

WHILE YOU LISTEN

Things to spot, and what is real

A few small things to listen for, and a note on what is found and what is imagined.

THINGS TO SPOT IN THE EPISODE

- The signed inscription above the Imperial Gate (Ali b. Yahya es-Sufi, 1478)
- The grilled window of the Tower of Justice above the council hall
- The iron leaf of the Middle Gate signed by Isa b. Mehmed (931 / 1524–1525)
- Library shutters closed over books that may not leave the room
- The fountain's two taps by the library stair before dawn

WHAT WE KNOW, AND WHAT WE IMAGINE

The palace, its gates, kitchens, library, kiosks and customs are historical, and the dates come from the record. The named ordinary people of this particular evening are imagined. The palace was long called the New Imperial Palace; the later name Topkapı comes from a seaside pavilion.





Artistic impressions made for the episode. They are not historical records.

FOR ANOTHER QUIET EVENING

Books to read

If you'd like to wander a little further, here are some trusted places to start.

📚 Find these books — tap here →

Full reading list ↗



An artistic impression made for the episode, not a historical record.

FOR ANOTHER QUIET EVENING

Museums, places and one last thought

Museums & places

Topkapı Palace Museum: the palace on Sarayburnu, made a museum on 3 April 1924; the present museum grounds (excluding Gülhane) cover about 350,000 square metres.

Presidency of National Palaces — Topkapı Palace: official site for the palace among the national palaces.

Fountain and sabil of Ahmed III: the fountain in the square between the Imperial Gate and Hagia Sophia (Museum With No Frontiers).

A BEDTIME QUESTION

If you walked these courts at night, where would you pause longest: the warm kitchens, the quiet library, or the terraces above the water?

"The courts grow quieter the farther you walk in, the library shutters keep their books, and water moves under the headland until the first pale light."

LISTEN TO THE FULL EPISODE ON YOUTUBE OR YOUTUBE MUSIC

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